

Electrosmog

A controversial topic, and you can find enough studies that suggest the opposite, but have a read <http://bit.ly/7emkw1>

Exercise at your PC

The most important time to exercise is when you're sitting in front of a PC for long hours. <http://bit.ly/TSZbN>

EXPERT OPINION

We spoke to Dr. Alexander Martin – Psychiatrist and Associate Professor, Psychological Medicine, Dr. DY Patil Medical College and Hospital, Navi Mumbai – to get a feel of the real picture from a specialist.

Q. Do you really feel technology is killing us? What is your take on this?

A. Personally if you ask me, I would not like to demonise technology. As humans, we've evolved through the ages and through our journey, we've come to use technology to make our lives easier. But then, with every good thing, there is also a flip side. The same holds true for technology as well.

With rapid advancements, we as humans are drawn to a virtual world of our own. What we really need to do is draw a line somewhere, so that

we master technology, rather than be slaves to it.

Q. Could you give us an example?

A. With the internet becoming so popular, it also serves as a vast storehouse of knowledge. With so much of information available online, young minds do not know what information is good and what is bad. Consider web sites and forums. People are free to write information that stays online and is retrievable by search queries. But there's no way of authenticating that

People are free to write information that stays online and is retrievable by search queries. But there's no way of authenticating that information!

information! People surf for information on ailments and try medication too. You can't substitute the teacher or a human with technology.

Q. What do you have to say on social networking, often regarded as the biggest thing to happen to the web?

A. Personally, I do use Facebook. However, I control myself. I restrict it to 10 to 15 minutes a day or maximum of half an hour. Even this is a lot. The web site has helped me find friends that were long lost. However, I do find people that become anxious in the absence of internet access. The moment their internet connection is not working, they become restless. These are signs of an addiction.

Q. So you consider people who tweet by the minutes through the day as an addiction?

A. Yes certainly that is an addiction. It's something you are hooked on to. If you put in excessive time, energy, or if you become a slave to something, then you are certainly addicted. That means you cannot do without it. Signs of agitation and irritation in the absence of something are the surest signs of an addiction.

Q. How does one strike a balance?

A. If you decide to spend a fixed amount of time, such as half-an-hour, as I shared with you, that would make a difference. It's all about time management. For example, if you are supposed to be sleeping, or eating or spending time with your family, but you are on the net instead, spending time in your virtual world, then it certainly can lead to problems. At the end it boils down to how disciplined we are with ourselves.

other's lives before going off and partaking in individual hobbies.

When not indoors exercising our grey matter by reading books, or stoking our imaginations by reading comics, we would be outdoors, playing cricket – unless it was a football World Cup year...

The new millennium

Fast forwarding past all those memories between school and college – which perhaps only I would attach any value to anyway – we arrive unceremoniously at about a decade past the new millennium.

Just like anyone else my age, I'd spent the last few years smack in the middle of the rat race, elbowing my way through the pack to attain my hard fought status of mediocrity. I'd worked hard for what I had, which wasn't much, but I knew that if I were lucky, I'd still have about 25 years of working life ahead of me to try and close the gap between middle-class and rich... OK, perhaps upper-middle-class is where I ended up.

During all those years I fast-forwarded you through, one major change occurred – personal technology! Obviously, I can't live without it anymore, although I seem to have gotten along fine before it found its way into

my pocket. However, for quite a while, technology was the secret to my success. It helped me get ahead; I got more done, and did it faster than ever before. I was blessed with the ability to quickly learn any new technology, and was able to keep up with the rapid changes.

Life was good; sure I was working hard, but then again, who wasn't? Thanks to my trusty phone and my notebook, I was able to work from anywhere. And I do mean literally, *anywhere*. The advantage technology brought about was that I could now truly multi-task. I was able to reply to emails whilst eating dinner at a restaurant and nodding in acknowledgement at the conversations my family members were having. Every now and then I would run out of signal or battery life, but a mad dash out into the open, or to a nearby plug point, was quickly able to remedy that.

There used to be a time when I had reception problems at home, but that was thankfully remedied when my service provider erected a cell tower right opposite my living room window to make sure I, and others like me, would stay connected and online 365/24/7. I even remember feeling jealous of the neighbour, who was actually paid to lease his roof to the provider. His claims of also being given unlimited calls and services for all his family

members as a bonus were never substantiated, but it did turn me greener at the time.

Technology was also able to help me keep in touch with people like never before. Thanks to sites like Facebook, I was able to have short conversations or get information about friends who I was geographically separated from. Of course that geographic separation could

NEED A LEG-UP?

<http://bit.ly/dB4X>

A Honda prototype that helps people walk! What next? Something to help us get out of bed, or perhaps something to help you brush your own teeth? They are after all such tedious tasks aren't they?



be across the Indian and Atlantic oceans, or across the road... In those busy times, friends who weren't work mates, and who didn't visit the same joints as I did to unwind, might as well have been an ocean away anyway.

Yes, life was good indeed, and technology had helped free up so much wasted time. I